

Grammar & Punctuation

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Abbreviations

- It's OK to abbreviate words in charts, graphs, and captions if needed. If in a chart, don't use a period after the abbreviated word.

Example: avg ✓ avg. ✗

- Abbreviate "number" as no. with a period.

Ampersands

Avoid using an ampersand wherever possible.

Don't use an ampersand in a full sentence.

Use an ampersand:

- In CTA buttons to make it shorter.
- In a title, subhead, or menu item where there is no room for 'and'
- For phrases like 'Plans & Pricing'
- In initialisms (abbreviations where the letters are pronounced individually) like R&D
- In trademarked or product names, like 'AT&T.'

Example: Save & Enable SSO

Acronyms

Acronyms and abbreviations can have an adverse effect on clarity and voice. Although some acronyms are widely understood and preferred to the spelled-out term, others aren't well known.

- Don't create acronyms from product or feature names
- If you have to use an acronym, also spell out the term for clarity
In general, include the acronym in parentheses following the spelled-out term. On subsequent mentions in the same article, page, or screen, you can use the acronym without spelling it out. Some acronyms, like USB, FAQ, and URL, are more well known than the spelled-out term. Don't spell out the term if the acronym is listed in [The American Heritage Dictionary](#) or if the A–Z word list says to use the acronym without spelling it out.
- If an acronym will appear only once in your content, just spell out the term. Don't introduce it in parentheses after the spelled-out version.
- Avoid using an acronym for the first time in a title or heading.
- Don't capitalize the spelled-out form of an acronym unless it's a proper noun.

Colons

Preceding lists

Include a colon at the end of a phrase that directly introduces a list.

Example

Create a backup of all sorts of things, such as:

- Apps you've installed on your phone
- Your call history.

In titles and headings

When you use a colon in a title or heading, capitalize the word that follows it.

Examples

Block party: Communities use Minecraft to create public spaces

Why girls lose interest in STEM: New research has some answers

Commas

- Use the Oxford or serial comma. The Oxford comma is used before the conjunction in a list of three or more items

Example

- Save your file to a hard drive, an external drive, or the cloud.

Writing tip: If a series contains more than three items or the items are long, consider a bulleted list to improve readability

- Use comma (,) after e.g. if it's a full sentence or phrase. *Example:* e.g., thanks for reaching out

Exclamation marks

In general, don't use them (!!!!!). Use sparingly, only if needed. This aligns with our Product Voice and Tone, as we don't want to be jumpy. Using exclamation marks in an email also makes it more likely to be flagged as spam. Exceptions & where to use:

- In positive affirmations such as success message toasts.

Example

All done! You've successfully created a project. Manage them under Organization.

Ellipsis

In general, avoid using the ellipsis in a sentence

Dashes and Hyphenation

En and Em dashes

Try to not use an En dash, even though it may be technically accurate. Add a hyphen with a space before and after to show a range.

Avoid Em dashes as they break the flow of the copy. Use comma, period, or another sentence instead.

Hyphen

- Include space before and after to show a range.

Example: 2pm - 7pm

- Hyphenate adjective phrases and noun phrases without spaces in between

Example:

Opt-out

All-in-one

Parantheses

Use parentheses to define acronyms, initialisms or terms unique to the company. You can also use parentheses when you can't use dynamic copy to show singular and plural options. Use parentheses with an (s) to show the plural form.

Example: Monthly Active Users (MAU)

{{3}} out of {{4}} invoice(s) failed to process.

Periods

Use end punctuation in:

- Body copy such as descriptions
- Subheading
- Hint text

Don't use end punctuation in:

- Headlines
- UI titles such as Alerts or Modals
- Simple lists (three or fewer words per item)
- In bulleted lists that don't have a complete sentence or phrase
- In snackbars and toasts (use in between two sentences)
- Sentences or examples in text areas and input fields
- After links

End all complete sentences with a period, and put one space, not two after a period.

Headline example

Be brief—make every word count

Text example

Be brief. Make every word count.

Period placement with other punctuation

Periods go inside quotation marks. They go outside parentheses when the parenthetical is part of a larger sentence, and inside parentheses when the parenthetical stands alone.

- Daniel said, "I ate a burger."
- Hotel rooms are likely to be in short supply throughout August (the peak travel period).
- Their house was the largest one on the block. (It also happened to be the ugliest.)

Question Marks

Use questions sparingly. In general, customers want us to give them answers.

When a customer needs to make a decision, a question is appropriate.

Example: Do you want to save your changes?

Quotation Marks

Use double quotation marks (" ") not single quotation marks (' ').

Place closing quotation marks:

- Outside commas and periods.
- Inside other punctuation.

Exception: If punctuation is part of the quoted material, place it inside the quotation marks.

Examples:

- One type of malware is called a "trojan clicker."

- She provides a thorough list of problems in her most recent article, “Misery in Paradise”; she doesn’t provide a solution.